How geography is used, and consequently understood, varies over time – depending on technology, infrastructure, people-to-people and state-to-state connectivity, and economic and political barriers. Arabs, Malays, Chinese, and peoples on the Indian subcontinent traded across the Indian and Pacific Oceans for centuries before the age of Western Imperialism altered these old trading networks. Then followed five decades of the Cold War, with economic and political barriers hampering connectivity in this vast area.

Unlike the time when Britain ruled the waves and had an empire on which the sun never set, the Indian Ocean is no longer a closed space with access denied to other powers. In recent years, we have witnessed unprecedented connectivity between the Indian Ocean Region and the Asia-Pacific region. C. Raja Mohan argued in 2012 that Chinese naval outreach to the Indian Ocean and India's rising profile in the western Pacific were beginning to "fashion the Indo-Pacific into a single geopolitical theatre."[5] Now that these two regions are once again interlinked, it challenges the prevailing semantics, meaning that old habits and names used to describe Asia have to be supplemented or replaced by new practices and labels more fitting to today's realities.

Henceforth, addressing the issue of Indo–US relations or India–China relations in the context of the Indo-Pacific makes sense, for when we speak of the Asia-Pacific or Trans-Pacific, scholars and analysts often confine themselves to discussing only the Americas and East Asia. Strange as it may appear to scholars and newspaper readers in the future, even Asia was once depicted by the US State Department as composed of just East and Southeast Asia. Aaron L. Friedberg, in his much-quoted 1994 article "Ripe for Rivalry," used a map sourced from the Department of State Bulletin that excluded South Asia, Central Asia, and the countries of the Persian Gulf and West Asia, all of which are now considered an intrinsic part of Asia.[6]